



Security Watch

Yahoo! Messenger Vulnerabilities

The Problem

A pair of serious vulnerabilities have been reported in Yahoo! Messenger. These could enable a hacker to run malicious code with minimal user intervention if the messaging client is running in the background.

In the first vulnerability, a remote attacker could compromise a machine running a webcam on Yahoo! Messenger by causing a buffer overflow in its ActiveX component when the user visits a Web page with malicious HTML code. The result is that more data is sent to the RAM than it can handle, causing the program or other services running on the computer to crash, or the execution of harmful code. The second exploit causes a buffer overflow in the file ywcwvr.dll, which is used in the viewer component of the messenger client.

eEye Digital Security, the company that discovered the exploits, gave them its highest risk rating. Secunia, another computer security company, labelled it "extremely critical."

The Solution

Yahoo! has released a patch for the exploits, stating that everyone using their messenger client should download the updated version from <http://messenger.yahoo.com/download.php>. Yahoo!'s description of the exploit can be found at http://messenger.yahoo.com/security_update.php?id=060707.

NEW SENSOR TECH

Let There Be Light

No more low-light worries: Kodak has leapt into the limelight with new sensor technology. Kodak has said that their new technology will go a long way in overcoming light issues by increasing light sensitivity, which is one of the biggest pains in the neck for professional photographers and amateurs alike. Insufficient light makes for noise in the output image: grains, multi-coloured speckles, and other unwanted elements.

The majority of the sensors in digital cameras use the Bayer filter. This is a chequerboard grid where green pixels make up 50 per cent, and red and blue make up 25 per cent each. Now, neutral, "panchromatic" pixels will be added to the array along with the usual red, blue, and green pixels. Panchromatic pixels are sensitive to all wavelengths, and collect a larger amount of light when it hits the sensor. This will result in a more true-to-life image. The images will also be reconstructed using a different algorithm.

Steve Hoffenberg, an analyst with Lyra Research Inc. has said, "Typically, new features like this would be more likely to show up in high-end

products and then trickle down. But I think the biggest potential benefit of this may come in the camera phone environment. Camera phones are using smaller sensors to begin with and smaller sensors generally mean smaller pixels, which means lower sensitivity."

Kodak will first incorporate this feature in their own cameras and then offer it to other camera manufacturers in the first quarter of 2008.

Certain analysts have expressed scepticism about the technology. Christopher Chute, an analyst from IDC research has said, "They have been guarded about their portfolio, with certain degrees of success. But at the end of the day you need to have invented something or have some kind of intellectual property in order to maintain a market position."

However, Kodak intends to make up for it: it is estimated that they will receive about \$250 million (Rs 110 crore) in royalties and related revenues: every month, the market is hit by new camera models with added features: Kodak's technology has the potential to become widespread, Chute said. "But first it needs to prove itself. It can't just be a lab rat." Kodak does need to innovate beyond their existing camera line-up besides the technical enhancements they've come up with.

HOT

Think iPhone...



Multi-touch screens are right in. With the iPhone and Microsoft's Surface—as in the "touch-table"—having taken off, the technology is here to stay. It enables multiple users to operate a device together. Imagine scenarios like interactive walls and tabletops...

...and styluses!

Input styluses tend to scratch screens, and the screens require calibration. It doesn't allow multiple inputs. Input area is small, and accuracy is demanded of the user. This input mechanism isn't out yet, but it's definitely not the way ahead.



NOT

A NEW INITIATIVE

Green Tech Getting Ahead

Global warming and e-waste are serious concerns. Over-consumption of power by electrical and electronic gadgets—as well as PCs and servers—doesn't help the cause: when the equipment is disposed, the resulting e-waste can cause upset the ecological balance. The Government estimates that 1,46,000 tons of e-waste is produced annually in India in the major cities.

Google and Intel have spanning-new plans towards



One Silly Question

"What's 'XP' in Windows XP for you?"



"eXclusively Pampered"
Dheeraj Kapoor



"eXPired"
Harshal Namdeo



"eXtremely Pathetic!"
Dina Thakkar



"eXcessive Pricing!"
Rachit Bakshi



"eXtra Phaltu!"
V. Harish